



Comprehensive Koala Plan of Management for south-east Lismore

Report 2022-25

JULY 2025

**Lismore City Council
Environmental Strategies**



Background

The Comprehensive Koala Plan of Management for south-east Lismore (CKPoM) aims to protect the koala population found in the southeast of the Lismore Local Government Area (LGA). The koala is classified as endangered at state and national levels. The Lismore LGA supports one of the most significant koala populations in NSW, in part due to greater population declines being experienced in most other areas¹. The CKPoM was 18 years in the making and was approved by the NSW Department of Planning in 2013. Lismore City Council (LCC) adopted the CKPoM in 2013.

The plan provides direction on how to manage threats to koalas and their habitat. It contains policy and planning provisions which guide how development applications are assessed, incorporating koala conservation principles to ensure koalas have viable natural habitat and food trees in the southeast of the LGA.

The CKPoM also details a range of management activities that aim to address threats to koala health and welfare including the clearing of habitat, disease, vehicle strikes and dog attacks. The implementation of these activities is managed by LCC's Environmental Strategies team, within the Planning and Environment department. This report provides a stand-alone 'snapshot' to provide an update on our progress towards implementation of CKPoM management actions for the financial years 2022-25. The CKPoM requires a regular monitoring report on the progress of implementing the management activities identified in the Plan, any additional activities that may be required, and the amount of food trees and koala habitat retained, removed, restored and/or replaced.

LCC's Biodiversity Management Strategy (BMS) is the key policy document guiding biodiversity management in the LGA and it continues to implement management actions outlined in the CKPoM. Annual reporting on the CKPoM is currently included in BMS reporting & review process, including via an annual report on the Special Rate Variation which funds the BMS & largely CKPoM. Although Action 2 of the CKPoM non-regulatory actions table proposes that 'the Koala Advisory Group is to produce a regular monitoring report on the effectiveness of this Plan to Council', due to complexity of issues and unreasonable demands on volunteer time, contemporary process is that reporting on the CKPoM (as for all other BMS activities) is the responsibility of Council staff.

Overall action implementation status

The CKPoM lists 38 separate actions which have been progressed over the life of the plan. Of these actions, all have had some level of activity (Figure 1). 45% of actions are considered complete. 32% require ongoing works over the life of the plan, while about a quarter are currently in action but are not yet completed. A small number of these actions require review as to their relevance, due to changes in external context and needs. This external context includes changes in State Environmental Planning Policies (SEPPs) such as the Koala Habitat Protection SEPP:

- 2019: State Environmental Planning Policy (Koala Habitat Protection) 2019 replaced SEPP 44.
- November 2020: State Environmental Planning Policy (Koala Habitat Protection) 2020 replaced and repealed the 2019 Koala SEPP. The 2020 SEPP applies to the RU1, RU2 and RU3 zones in 74 LGAs, including Lismore.
- March 2021: State Environmental Planning Policy (Koala Habitat Protection) 2021 commenced. It applies across all zones in the 8 Sydney Metropolitan Councils and Central Coast and to zones other than RU1, RU2 and RU3 for the remaining 74 councils.

(List sourced from: <https://www.planning.nsw.gov.au/Policy-and-Legislation/Environment-and-Heritage/Koala-Habitat-Protection-SEPP>)

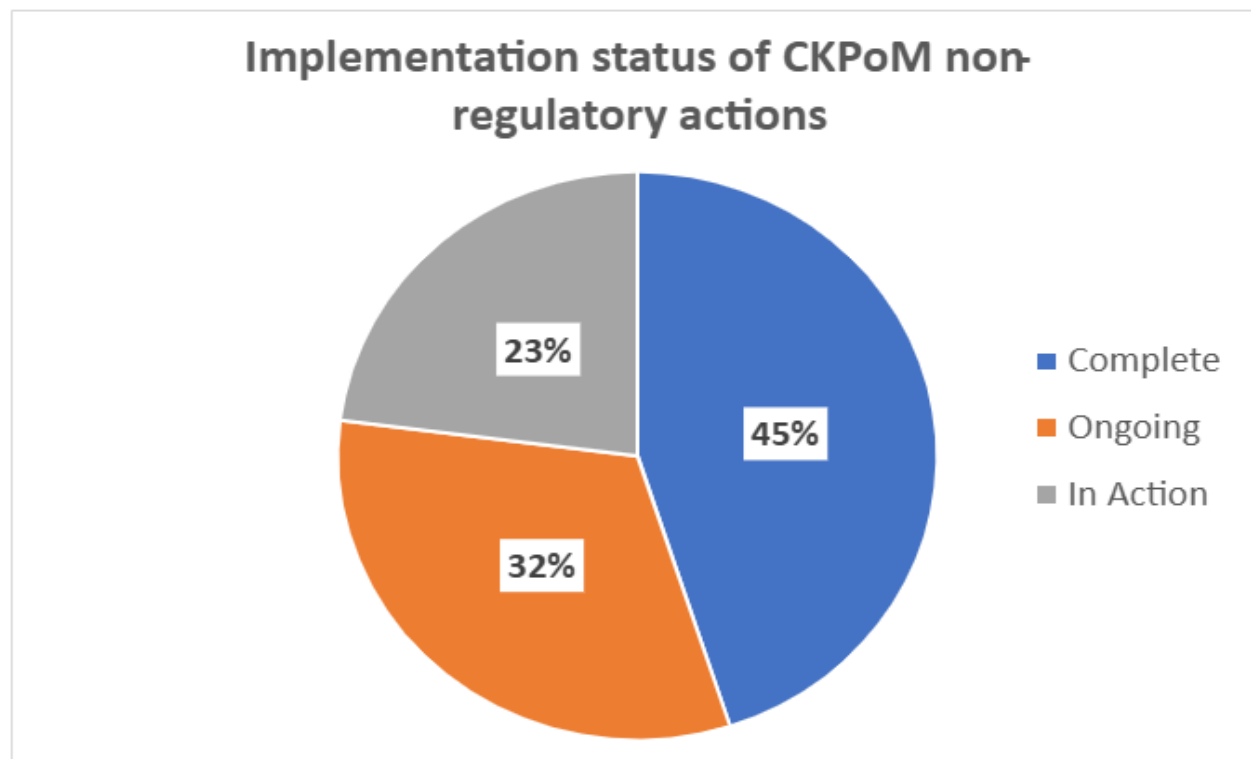


Figure 1. Overall action implementation status figures (based on CKPoM working actions table. Details available on request).

Koala monitoring 2023/24

Management action 29 of the CKPoM requires Council to undertake the monitoring of koala activity in the south-east of the Lismore LGA, which LCC conducts every 3 years. The third round of this monitoring was completed by Biolink Ecological Consultants during the 2023/24 financial year. This study included 75 field surveys using the Spot Assessment Technique (SAT) method, which involves searching for koala scat under koala feed trees in the CKPoM area to determine activity levels (Figure 2). In addition, a desktop examination of the LGA-wide historical koala records between 2017-22 was undertaken to further explore where they are living and the impact of key threats.

Results showed that Lismore's koala population appears to be holding steady, and they remain widely distributed. Lismore's koalas do not appear to be experiencing the declines of many other areas, with the Richmond River floodplain having the highest koala occupancy known in the Northern Rivers. However, it should be noted that high levels of habitat occupancy do not necessarily equate to high levels of population abundance. The results also indicated that the CKPoM population may have plateaued as remaining koala habitat is likely near the maximum number of koalas it can supportⁱⁱ. This suggests that without increasing habitat the local koala population is unlikely to grow further, and the population remains vulnerable to unexpected events like a new disease or a change in the environment or climatic conditions.

Consistent with previous studies, the main contributors to recorded koala deaths were disease (58%), vehicle-strike (23%) and dog attack (6%). Chlamydia related illness is the most common disease, with females being substantially more impacted than males. Analysis of the 302 known koala vehicle-strikes between 2017-2023, revealed four major and nine minor blackspots, with no significant change in the number of strikes compared to previous studies.

These monitoring studies provide a targeted snapshot into the current activity and distribution of Lismore's koala population. The results are crucial to helping Council and other land managers make decisions for koalas, including where Council should focus on habitat restoration, revegetation, road strike mitigation and community education.

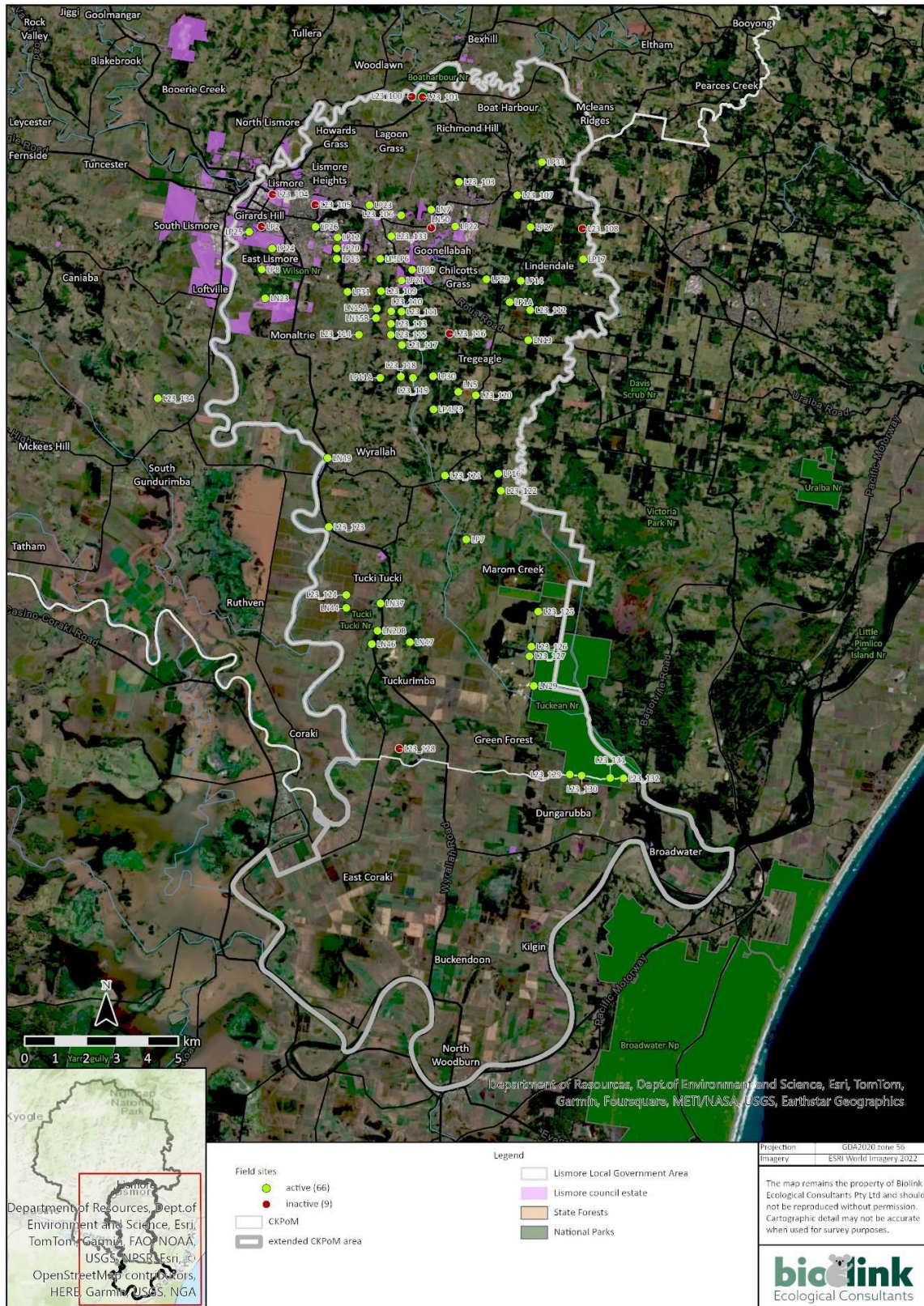


Figure 2. Locations of 74 sampled field sites across the extended CKPoM planning area, with an additional site to the west, in South Gundurimba. Green sites are active, red inactive. (Biolink Ecological Consultants, 2024).

Habitat Conservation, Restoration and Management

Council contributes funding each financial year from the BMS towards koala habitat conservation, restoration and management. It does this primarily through the Koala Habitat Restoration Program, the Roadside High Conservation Value Vegetation program, Urban Green Corridors program and through the Rural Landholder Initiative (RLI). Council also takes part in partnership projects with key stakeholders when possible. The RLI program has delivered the most extensive number of these projects over the last three financial years (Figure 3).

On-ground investment in koala habitat restoration is prioritized within the CKPoM area wherever possible. However, this is challenging as most koala habitat in this area is in private ownership, so investment relies upon consent being granted or applications for conservation work being received. Strategic investment in habitat restoration outside of the CKPoM area has benefit to koalas across the LGA, through improved movement enabling genetic flow and enhanced habitat improving population health and reducing disease.

Rural Landholder Initiative – Koala Projects

- The RLI is an annual grants program providing support for biodiversity conservation on private land and includes the koala as a target species. RLI grants typically run for two to three years and are funded to between \$5,000 and \$7,500, with landholders making an equal or greater in-kind contribution.
- From July 2022 to July 2025 a total of 39 RLI projects involving some degree of koala habitat restoration have been funded by Council. Nine of these projects have been located within the CKPoM area (Figure 3). Key metrics from these projects are in Table 1.

Table 1. Round 9,10 &11 RLI projects focusing on koala habitat

RLI Round	Number of planted koala trees	Planted area of koala habitat (ha)	Area of koala habitat under restoration (ha)	LCC Investment
Nine	1620	3.15	15.5	\$115,000
Ten	650	3.1	13	\$77,500
Eleven	1760	2.2	10.4	\$83,200
TOTAL	4030	8.45	38.9	\$275,700
TOTAL WITHIN CKPoM AREA	1885	2.0	3.8	\$49,900

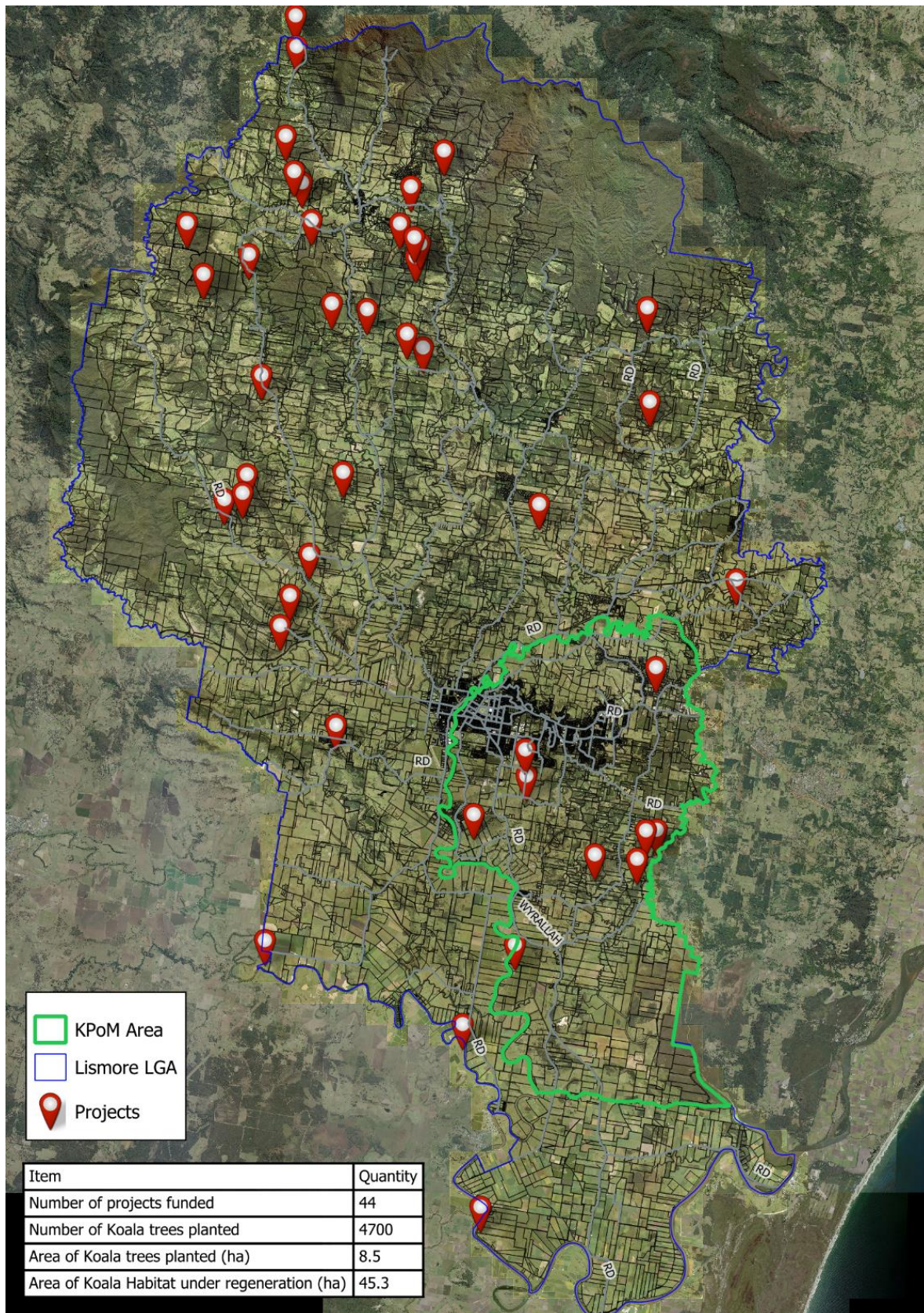


Figure 3. Locations of RLI and Roadside High Conservation Value Vegetation projects involving koala habitat restoration works from July 2022 to July 2025.

Koala Habitat Restoration Program

- LCC contributes approximately \$30,000 per year from the BMS towards a Koala Habitat Restoration Program, delivered through the Rural Landholder Initiative (RLI) and by partnership projects with key stakeholders.

Roadside High Conservation Value Vegetation Program

- During the period July 2022 – June 2025 Council has undertaken restoration work in strategic roadside high conservation value sites containing existing koala habitat. In these cases, the roadside vegetation represents the best (and often, only) koala habitat in the surrounding area, so the potential risk of roadstrike is outweighed by the benefit of habitat restoration. Works have only been performed in roadside sites that are away from main roads and where the speed limit is lower.
- 4 hectares have been restored, or are under restoration, across sites in Tregeagle, Ruthven, East Coraki and Blue Knob.

Urban Green Corridors Program

- Works are undertaken as a part of LCC's Urban Green Corridors Program to help maintain and restore koala habitat at sites such as Airfield Road and Highfield Terrace.
- A total of 2.19 hectares of koala habitat revegetation work has taken place in the UGCP area since July 2022.

Habitat Restoration Archive

- The Northern Rivers Koala Habitat Restoration Archive is a regional collaborative project with an aim of establishing an enduring archive of koala habitat restoration sites in the Northern Rivers region of NSW, described using standard data entry forms and hosted on the Atlas of Living Australia. This project was developed following the Koala Forum in 2020 which was supported by LCC and highlighted the need to record our on-ground effort as a high priority for all the participants.
- LCC has worked with Dr Peggy Eby to upload all past RLI projects which will enable regional mapping of funded works in the Northern Rivers region. This mapping will allow Council and other partners to form important links between funded projects and help prioritise areas for future focus. Mapping of koala projects on public and private land into the archive is ongoing and will be updated annually.
- Council is currently in the process of updating all projects from 2022 to the end of the 2024/25 financial year.

Regional Koala Partnership- Department of Climate Change, Energy, Environment and Water (DCCEEW) Koala Program

- Council staff attend quarterly meetings of the Northern Rivers Koala Network.
- The Northern Rivers Koala Network was formed to guide the rollout of the 2021-26 Regional Koala Partnership, which oversees the Regional Koala Officer as well as implementation of the Far North Coast Regional Conservation Strategy. The Network consists of seven regional Councils, NSW DCCEEW, Friends of the Koala (FOK) and several other stakeholders.

Road and Traffic Management

The Wildlife Roadkill Mitigation Report (WRMR) for the Lismore Local Government LGA (Sandpiper, 2019) identified and prioritised major wildlife road strike hotspots. Each site was assessed, and a toolbox of actions suggested to mitigate further road strikes at these sites. Actions ranged from speed reduction and Vehicle Activated Signs (VAS) to more frequent slashing of roadside vegetation or fencing off high risk hotspots.

- Since 2020-21 Variable Message Signage (VMS) boards have been used at the worst koala roadstrike hotspots throughout the Lismore LGA. VMS boards are temporarily installed on roadsides during the koala breeding season. These boards are used with koala specific messaging and traffic counters to measure vehicle speeds to determine whether the signage is influencing drivers to lower their speed. Until 2023 these boards were hired by Council with the hire costs covered by funding from the NSW Saving our Species program and topped up with funding from the BMS.
 - Funding was provided by NSW DCCEEW during 2023 that allowed Council to purchase two VMS trailers to be used specifically for koala messaging. As a result, hiring of VMS is no longer necessary.
 - Analysis of speed and roadstrike data is continuing throughout the 2025 koala breeding season, with results informing future management actions for roadstrike mitigation.



Figure 4. Example of a Variable Message Signage (VMS) board, used throughout the LGA to raise driver awareness about koalas.

- \$1 million funding from NSW DCCEEW was secured in recent years for a project to install koala exclusion fencing, and a fauna underpass, along the Bruxner Highway at the Tatham Road intersection, which is considered the LGAs worst hotspot for koala roadstrike.
 - This project had been on hold following the 2022 natural disaster. The recovery of this flooding event caused significant delays due to project management constraints and availability.
 - The project is now progressing with a steering committee, landholder agreements, and a design in place. Council is working with Transport for NSW to obtain approval to commence construction works.
- During 2022/23 the NSW Koala Program (DCCEEW) provided \$90K to repair the existing Skyline Road koala exclusion fence.

Dog Management

- LCC continues to communicate with the community about dog management and koalas, including distributing brochures and information developed via regional partnership with the Regional Koala Officer
- LCC has an ongoing working relationship with Local Land Services regarding wild dog management in rural areas.

Koala Health and Welfare

- Council continues to provide support to Friends of the Koala (FOK) which is licensed to carry out rescue and rehabilitation of diseased and injured koalas across 5 of the local government areas in the Northern Rivers Region. Koalas in care at the Friends of Koala hospital require substantial volumes of fresh leaf each day. To provide food for koalas in care, LCC leases land to FOK to manage as food tree plantations.
- A number of these plantations are on floodplain sites and were impacted by the February 2022 floods. Support was provided to FOK to recover these sites including connection to disaster recovery and debris clean-up programs, and removal and management of debris.

Koala food trees and habitat retained, removed, restored and/or replaced

Several actions in the CKPoM relate to the quantification and mapping of the amount of koala food trees and habitat retained, removed, restored and/or replaced through the Development Application (DA) process. Major obstacles impeded these actions for several years including inaccuracies with vegetation mapping, lack of staff time/resources, challenges defining loss/gain/quality, historical DA processes and lag time in updates of the NSW Biodiversity Values Map. Considerable effort has been made to develop this process, with ongoing effort over several years resulting in a checklist process and a mapping layer being created. This process now applies to the whole of the LGA, not just the area covered by the CKPoM.

Table 2 indicates the amount of koala habitat removed, restored and/or replaced, since 2011, through the DA process and where records are sufficiently available. Most of the habitat restoration/replacement (offsetting) has occurred on private land.

Table 2. Amount of koala habitat removed, restored and/or replaced as a part of the DA process in the Lismore LGA since 2011.

Area of koala habitat removed (ha)	Koala food trees planted (individual trees)	Area of koala habitat under restoration (ha)	Area revegetated with koala habitat (ha)
14.1	6032	21.01	28.6

It should be noted that these figures only apply to vegetation removal/revegetation associated with the DA process and registered with LCC in a Vegetation Management Plan. They do not account for vegetation loss due to things like tree removal applications, illegal/unauthorized clearing, or authorized clearing under the Local Land Services Act on rural zoned land. The realistic amount of koala habitat removed in the Lismore LGA is likely to be higher than what is reported above. The development of this process has led to a recommendation being made for Council to better track instances of these events where possible.

ⁱ Biolink Ecological Consultants. (2017). Koala Habitat & Population Assessment Lismore Local Government Area (part), Final Report to Lismore City Council. September 2017

ⁱⁱ Biolink. (2024). *Lismore Koala Plan of Management: Monitoring*. Report to Lismore City Council by Biolink Ecological Consultants, Pottsville, NSW.

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